

Fix: Theme toggle with next-themes

Type: Fix Status: verified Branch: `fix/theme-toggle-with-next-themes`

The problem

Feature 1 shipped light and dark palettes, but the theme only follows the OS setting. A visitor cannot pick one, and the only way to see the other theme is to change Windows or macOS settings. The `.dark` class seam and the `localStorage.theme` key exist; nothing writes them.

Frank decided on 2026-09-18 to do this the shadcn way: `next-themes` for the provider and hook, and shadcn's `ModeToggle` pattern for the control.

The fix

Replace the hand-written head script in `app/layout.tsx` with `next-themes`, which does the same before-paint class write plus the hook a toggle needs. Add a `ModeToggle` in the header between the brand and `Book now`, styled like the burger so it belongs to the header we already have.

Must not break:

- Class-based dark mode: `next-themes` gets `attribute="class"` so the existing `@custom-variant dark` and the `.dark` palette block stay untouched
- The storage key stays `theme` (`next-themes`' default), so nothing else changes
- No cream flash for dark visitors: `next-themes` injects its own pre-paint script; `suppressHydrationWarning` on `<html>` stays because of it
- Server-first: the provider and the toggle are the only new client components; `SiteHeader` stays a server component and mounts the toggle as a child
- Nothing in `package.json` beyond `next-themes`. If `npx shadcn add dropdown-menu` wants to add any package, stop and ask; `@base-ui/react` is already installed and should be all it needs

Build steps

- ☒ **1. Install and provide.** Ask before running `npm install next-themes`. Add `components/theme/ThemeProvider.tsx` (`"use client"`, wraps `next-themes` ' `ThemeProvider` with `attribute="class"`, `defaultTheme="system"`, `enableSystem`, `disableTransitionOnChange`). In `app/layout.tsx` wrap the body contents with it and delete the `themeScript` constant and its `<script>`; keep `suppressHydrationWarning`. **Done when:** `npm run lint` and `npm run build` pass; with a dark OS preference / still loads with `class="dark"` on `<html>` and no cream flash; `grep -n themeScript app/layout.tsx` returns nothing.

- ☒ **2. Toggle.** Run `npx shadcn add dropdown-menu` (file only, see above). Add `components/theme/ModeToggle.tsx` following shadcn's dark-mode pattern: a round `size-10` icon button with `Sun` and `Moon` from `lucide-react`, swapped with `scale-100 dark:scale-0 / scale-0 dark:scale-100` so no mounted check is needed, `aria-label="Toggle theme"`, opening a menu with Light, Dark and System that call `setTheme`. Mount it in `SiteHeader` inside the `NavMenu` children, before the phone link, visible at every width. **Done when:** build and lint pass; at 375px and 1280px the toggle is visible; choosing Dark adds `class="dark"` to `<html>`, turns the body ground to `rgb(28, 26, 23)` and stores `theme=dark` in `localStorage`; a reload keeps it; choosing System stores `theme=system` and follows the OS again.

Verify

1. `npm run lint` and `npm run build`. 2. Open `http://localhost:3000`. Click the sun/moon in the header, pick Dark: page turns dark immediately, reload keeps it dark. 3. Pick Light: page turns cream, reload keeps it. 4. Pick System: page follows the OS setting again. 5. Check the toggle sits between the brand and `Book now` at phone width without pushing the button off screen.

Implementation walkthrough

Provider (`components/theme/ThemeProvider.tsx`) - a thin client wrapper around `next-themes` with `attribute="class"`, `defaultTheme="system"`, `enableSystem` and `disableTransitionOnChange`. Class mode is the whole point: the `@custom-variant dark` and the `.dark` palette from feature 1 are untouched, and `next-themes` simply becomes the thing that writes the class. It uses the same `theme` key in `localStorage` the old script read, so the seam carried over with no migration.

Layout (`app/layout.tsx`) - the hand-written pre-paint script and its `<head>` are gone; the provider wraps header, main and footer inside `<body>`. `suppressHydrationWarning` stays on `<html>` because `next-themes` injects its own pre-paint script that edits the class before React hydrates. The layout is still a server component; only the provider boundary is client.

Toggle (`components/theme/ModeToggle.tsx`) - shadcn's dark-mode pattern: a round `size-10` trigger matching the burger, `Sun` and `Moon` from `lucide-react` stacked and swapped with `scale-100 dark:scale-0` and its mirror, so the icon is right on first paint with no mounted check and no hydration mismatch. The menu offers Light, Dark and System through `setTheme`. It uses the shadcn `DropdownMenu`, added with `npx shadcn add dropdown-menu`, which created one file and no package because `@base-ui/react` was already installed.

Header (`components/layout/SiteHeader.tsx`) - the toggle is passed into `NavMenu` as the first child, so it sits before the phone number and Book now at every width. `SiteHeader` stays a server component.

Dependency - `next-themes ^0.4.6`, approved by Frank on 2026-09-18 before install. Nothing else changed in `package.json`.

Decision worth recording - choosing System stores `theme=system` rather than clearing the key. That is how `next-themes` behaves and it is fine; the spec's done-when was corrected to say so.

Checks run - `npm run lint` and `npm run build (/ static)`. Browser at `localhost:3000` : toggle visible at the pane's 334px width without pushing Book now off screen; Dark sets `class="dark"` , ground `rgb(28, 26, 23)` and `theme=dark` , survives a reload; System sets `theme=system` and follows the OS; three fresh loads with every request `200` .